



What Time Is It, Eccles?

Neil Maiden

THE GOON SHOW was the original surreal English comedy show. Performed in the 1950s, it predated Monty Python by 15 years and laid the foundations and standards for what followed.

One of the sketches always resonated with me but I'd never really understood why. Sure, the sketch is smart and funny. And it's beautifully circular and self-contained—a near-perfect storm of comedy.

Recently, I listened to the sketch again (*The Goon Show* was a radio show), and this time I got it. It resonated because the sketch says so much about how we work, including how we do requirements work in software projects.

You can read the full transcript of the sketch in the sidebar “A Piece of Paper” but in brief, it goes something like this:

Bluebottle and Eccles are chatting in a room full of ticking clocks. Bluebottle, voiced by the great Peter Sellers, asks Eccles for the time. Bluebottle, in the form of the even greater Spike Milligan, replies that it's 8 o'clock. “How do you know?” asks Bluebottle. Eccles replies that he's got the time written on a piece of paper. He got it from someone who wrote the time down for him.

“Ah,” says Bluebottle, “but what if the time isn't 8 o'clock?” The paper only shows 8 o'clock.

“Then I don't show it to them,” replies Eccles, confidently. Why should he? It isn't 8 o'clock. Bluebottle then holds the piece of paper to his ear, discovers it isn't ticking, and reveals the piece of paper to be a fake!

Bluebottle then suggests... well, per-

haps you should read the rest of the sketch yourself. It's a joy to behold.

So, apart from the intrinsic beauty of the sketch, what is it that the sketch says to us today? For me it's the observation that the world is full of people who, whatever the question, always give the same answer. We perceive this in so many aspects of our lives. Our politicians trot out the same old platitudes, whatever the incisive interview question. Our football coaches always make the same excuses for yet another defeat. And our public transport systems always report the same reasons for being late.

In spite of however many ticking clocks we hear, we ignore them, in favor of doing the same thing, again and again.

Rather like us requirements folks, who keep using the same old techniques in our projects to elicit, acquire, and discover our customer's requirements.

I was struck by this again the other day. Running a requirements master class in a new part of the world, the participants told me the techniques they currently use to acquire requirements. Yes, you guessed it—questionnaires, interviews, and observations. We've been doing requirements acquisition since the 1980s and have developed dozens of different techniques, each shown to be effective in different situations. And yet most analysts don't use them.

Like Eccles, our time is always 8 o'clock, regardless of all of the ticking clocks that we can see and hear. Alas, not all of our clients are as forgiving as Bluebottle.

Whatever the Problem, Hit It with a Hammer

Before you write in, I'm not necessarily a downer on observations, interviews, and questionnaires. They have a valuable role to play in requirements projects. Observations give essential first-hand data about users and their problems. Unstructured interviews are flexible and can help acquire many different types of knowledge cost-effectively. Structured interviews ensure that analysts obtain requirements more systematically, while remaining flexible and adaptable. And questionnaires can collect large amounts of data from stakeholders in a standardized way in a relatively short time.

However, observations, interviews, and questionnaires also have well-documented weaknesses. Observing users can generate a lot of information but still not provide all the types of information that the analyst needs. Interviews rely on self-reporting—analysts only acquire what the stakeholders tell them. And, even if they want to, stakeholders can't communicate all the knowledge that you might want to acquire. For example, stakeholders often treat knowledge as taken for granted when it involves everyday things, forgetting that it might be unknown to outsiders, such as requirements analysts. Instead, taken-for-granted knowledge is best acquired using methods that don't rely on communication. Likewise, people can't communicate compiled knowledge—knowledge that was once accessible to reporting but which has been practiced



A PIECE OF PAPER

Originally aired on 7 Feb. 1957 as a short sequence on *The Goon Show* radio program, “What Time Is It, Eccles?” was written by Spike Milligan and features Milligan as Eccles and Peter Sellers as Bluebottle. Bluebottle and Eccles are clock repairers, listening to lots of timepieces ticking.

Bluebottle: What time is it, Eccles?

Eccles: Err, just a minute. I-I’ve got it written down ’ere on a piece of paper. A nice man wrote the time down for me this morning.

Bluebottle: Ooooh, then why do you carry it around with you, Eccles?

Eccles: Well, umm, if a-anybody asks me the ti-ime, I ca-can show it to dem.

Bluebottle: Wait a minute, Eccles, my good man...

Eccles: What is it, fellow?

Bluebottle: It’s writted on this bit of paper, what is 8 o’clock, is writted.

Eccles: I know that, my good fellow. That’s right, um, when I asked the fella to write it down, it was 8 o’clock.

Bluebottle: Well, then. Supposing when somebody asks you the time, it isn’t 8 o’clock?

Eccles: Ah, den I don’t show it to dem.

Bluebottle: Ooohhh...

Eccles: [Smacks lips] Yeah.

Bluebottle: Well, how do you know when it’s 8 o’clock?

Eccles: I’ve got it written down on a piece of paper!

Bluebottle: Oh, I wish I could afford a piece of paper with the time written on.

Eccles: Oohhhh.

Bluebottle: ’Ere, Eccles?

Eccles: Yah.

Bluebottle: Let me hold that piece of paper to my ear, would you? ’Ere. This piece of paper ain’t goin’.

Eccles: What? I’ve been sold a forgery!

Bluebottle: No wonder it stopped at 8 o’clock.

Eccles: Oh, dear.

Bluebottle: You should get one of them tings my grandad’s got.

Eccles: Oooohhh?

Bluebottle: His firm give it to him when he retired.

Eccles: Oooohhh.

Bluebottle: It’s one of dem tings what it is that wakes you up at 8 o’clock, boils the kettill, and pours a cuppa tea.

Eccles: Ohhh, yeah! What’s it called? Um.

Bluebottle: My granma.

Eccles: Ohh... Ohh, ah wait a minute. How does she know when it’s 8 o’clock?

Bluebottle: She’s got it written down on a piece of paper!

so often that it has become habitualized and sped up to the point where accurate introspection is no longer possible. Much computer-based work is like this. And questionnaires can be difficult to complete and are inflexible to different stakeholders and situations. I could go on....

Giving Requirements Analysts a Full Toolbox

So what’s the remedy? We need to give requirements analysts a new toolbox with both the right tools and, this time, the instructions to use them.

Techniques to include in the toolbox can come from many sources. Our original ACRE (Acquisition of Requirements) framework looked to knowledge acquisition to offer techniques

such as protocol analysis, card-sorting, and laddering.¹ But the boundaries between requirements analysis and other activities have blurred over the years. Today, requirements analysts should look to agile development techniques and user-centered design for techniques such as analysis of Web analytics, wire-framing, and user stories. We can also look to the creativity literature and take techniques such as constraint removal, storytelling, and other worlds. Do this, and our toolbox will soon be bulging.

But what about instructions to use these techniques? The ACRE was originally presented as tables in an academic paper.¹ This made sense at the time, but would we do that again now? No. Given the widespread experiences

that we all have with the techniques out there, I think that self-help manuals might be the best way forward. Not in paper form, but using social media to enable analysts and stakeholders to share their experiences about different techniques, rate them, and make information about them available to all.

So let’s help each other, and soon. The clock is ticking.... 

Reference

1. N.A.M. Maiden and G. Rugg, “ACRE: Selecting Methods for Requirements Acquisition,” *Software Eng. J.*, vol. 11, no. 3, 1996, 183–192.

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